

By Lindsay Krech-Bowles and Kathleen Becht

Most college programs for students with intellectual disability (ID) engage mentors to help support students with ID in their transition to college. Mentors are typically other college students who help connect these new college students to campus clubs, organizations, and services, and support them to engage in campus activities. Such mentor models are as diverse as the institutions in which the students are enrolled.

Across the country, mentors' responsibilities may focus on a few or all aspects of college life: academics, social life, residential living, and campus and community involvement (Culane et al., 2016; Carter and McCabe, 2021). Mentors may join an inclusive postsecondary education (IPSE) program as volunteers, paid student workers, or as students receiving academic credit for their service. The term mentor is used broadly here, to encompass many responsibilities, though programs may have divided up the responsibilities to different positions with titles, such as facilitator, peer mentor, tutor, ambassador, ally, job coach, academic coach, social coach, and others.

This document provides information to colleges and universities interested in establishing a mentor program by outlining three current mentor models. Table 1 illustrates three models for creating and managing mentor programs supporting students with ID: 1) a volunteer/friendship model at a private university, 2) a hybrid volunteer/service-learning model at a public state university, and 3) a primarily paid model at a community college. Differences between the programs reflect not only the mentor models of paid, volunteer, or service learning, but also the type of campus, (university or college), age, and size of the program (5–11 years; 5–40 students with ID and 8–140 mentors), and any dual purposes of the mentors themselves (course requirements fulfillment, paid employment).

DEFINING MENTORING

Foster Heckman and colleagues (2007) defined a reciprocity model of mentoring students with disabilities in postsecondary education as “a dynamic, reciprocal, long-term formal, or informal, relationship that focuses on personal and/or professional development [and social inclusion]. A mentor is a sounding board and guide. Mentors provide perspective, resources, and ask thought-provoking questions. In the ideal mentoring relationship, mentors and mentees, or protégés, learn from and teach each other” (p. 2). In adapting the definition to mentoring students with intellectual disability, Wilt and Morningstar (2020) added “and social inclusion” to the first sentence.

Developing a mentor program that fits your campus and your IPSE program can be difficult. Core components and promising practices of a mentor model can be found in each of the models described in Table 1. Core components for a mentor program for students with ID at the postsecondary level should include: (1) mentoring training/orientations, (2) regular supervision, (3) a system for communicating and collaborating, (4) co-equal relationships, (5) high expectations for students with ID, (6) identifying natural supports in students' environments, and (7) encouraging independence and self-advocacy.

Mentoring is “a dynamic, reciprocal, long-term formal, or informal, relationship that focuses on personal and/or professional development and social inclusion. A mentor is a sounding board and guide. Mentors provide perspective, resources, and ask thought-provoking questions. In the ideal mentoring relationship, mentors and mentees, or protégés, learn from and teach each other.”

The term *mentor* is used broadly here, to encompass many responsibilities though programs may have divided up the responsibilities to different positions with titles, such as facilitator, peer mentor, tutor, ambassador, ally, job coach, academic coach, social coach, and others.

Table 1. Three Mentor Models

	Vanderbilt University (VU) Next Steps Program	University of Georgia (UGA) Destination Dawgs Program	Tallahassee Community College (TCC) Eagle Connections Program
Campus Type	Private University, Tennessee Program age – 11 years	Public State University, Georgia Program age – 5 years	Community College, Florida Program age – 10 years
Mentor Model	Volunteer Mentor: Friendship Program intentionally shifts language toward “neurodiverse” and away from “intellectual disability” and wording that reflects the partnership and reciprocal learning that takes place, rather than words like “help and aide.”	Hybrid: Volunteer (66%) and Service Learning (33%) One-third of the mentors receive course credit through a service-learning practicum course. Mentor Webpage Resource	Paid or Service Learning Mentors are paid staff or work-study students. If they participate in an internship, they receive course credit. Mentor Handbook Resource
Mentor Title	Ambassa’Dores	Mentors	Mentors
Mentor: Student Ratio	3.5 to 1 • 140 undergraduate and graduate peer mentors • 40 students enrolled in the IPSE program	5.5 to 1 • 45 undergraduate and graduate peer mentors • 8 students enrolled in the IPSE program	1.6 to 1 • 8 undergraduate and graduate mentors • 5 students enrolled in the IPSE program
Mentor Time	2 hours/week The number of Ambassa’Dores paired with each student is customized, ranging from 2–10 Ambassa’Dores per student.	3 hours/week, averaging 30 hours per semester	10–15 hours/week
Philosophy	The Ambassa’Dores partner with students as they progress in their program, developing skills and establishing a sense of belonging. Neurodiverse is used in place of intellectual disability, to reflect equal partnerships and reciprocal learning. Mentor focus: The Ambassa’Dores program focuses on fostering genuine friendships, inclusion, and belonging. Ambassa’Dores participate for reciprocal friendship and learning. The intentional shift in language has helped authentic friendships evolve between students and mentors.	Destination Dawg students are fully included in UGA classes and activities with matriculated peers. There are no specialized or segregated classes/ events. Mentor focus: Destination Dawgs peer mentors are currently enrolled UGA students who volunteer and agree to appropriately support the Destination Dawg students (mentees) with whom they are matched in one or more of four areas: 1) academic, 2) health and wellness, 3) social, and/or 4) building independence.	Mentors are part-time staff, work-study students, or interns presenting positive role models while helping students navigate the new responsibilities as a college student. Mentor Focus: Mentors provide academic and social support the majority of the time that a student is on campus. Mentors should blend in and create as natural of an environment as possible while supporting the Eagle Connections students.

	Vanderbilt University (VU) Next Steps Program	University of Georgia (UGA) Destination Dawgs Program	Tallahassee Community College (TCC) Eagle Connections Program
Types of Supports	A Circle of Support structure supports each student. Mentors are paired with each student based on identified goals and level of support need. There is one lead mentor responsible for communication and coordination. Next Steps academic advisors and the director of campus life also support students. Students also meet weekly with advisors. Mentors provide 1:1 peer support to reach goals in: • organization and communication [daily planner] • academic growth [tutor] • socialization and social skill [lunch partner] • Physical activity [workout partner] • inclusion in campus organizations [campus life partner]	The mentor's job is to eventually work themselves out of a job by helping mentees develop strategies and natural supports in their campus environments. They make introductions and support students' engagement in organizations or social activities. Mentors support students' self-determined and informed choices. Mentors engage in the person-centered planning and supporting process. Mentees receive support in the areas of: • academics – in-class support, library navigation, study partners • health and wellness – dining companion, cooking, exercising • social engagement – student club/organization events, sporting events, service projects • increasing independence – housekeeping, meal preparation, financial management	The mentor's goal is to help mentees gain confidence and independence as they progress through the program with eventual fading of mentor support. Mentors provide academic and social support for students, though they are not tutors, counselors, or supervisors. Mentors may accompany students to class, exams, and meetings with faculty; serve as a study partner; and assist with scheduling, planning, and navigating the campus and resources. Mentors may also spend time with students during lunch and campus social events.
Recruitment, Hiring, Training and Support	Recruitment: Mentors are recruited through current mentor recommendations, campus advertising, class announcements, social media posts, campus events, and connections with other campus organizations. Hiring: The hiring process includes an application, background check, and protection of minors training. Training and Support: New mentors take part in a training session and an initial social event to build community and establish lines of support for new Ambassa'Dores. Staff also provide student leadership support, including structured check-ins, reference resources on Brightspace Learning Management System (LMS), monthly meetings with training on relevant and requested topics, and reviewing weekly notes.	Recruitment: The best mentor recruitment tool has been word of mouth. Mentors' majors include Disability Studies, Human Development and Family Sciences, Public Health, and Education. Mentors can use their hours to fulfill required internships. We are also exploring social work students for recruitment. Hiring: Most mentors are volunteers or engaged in service learning and are not employees. Mentor training, background checks, and volunteer agreements are required Training and Support: The full-time staff peer mentor coordinator provides ongoing support, including oversight of schedules, reviewing mentor reports, and responding to mentor and mentee questions and concerns as they arise. The service-learning course provides understanding and support in the application of person-centered practices.	Recruitment: This includes postings on the college website, outreach to volunteer organizations on campus, and outreach to nearby universities for undergraduate or graduates. Hiring: Mentors may be paid staff, work-study, or interns who get course credit online. They must complete a human resources (HR) application, interviews, a Level I and Level II background check, (fingerprinting, & reference checks), and a very intensive college onboarding process. Training and Support: Several trainings are required including FERPA, data security, work accounts, and the Program Mentor Training Academy, (certified by the College Reading and Learning Association, CRLA, Peer Educator program). See TCC's Mentor Handbook for more information.

	Vanderbilt University (VU) Next Steps Program	University of Georgia (UGA) Destination Dawgs Program	Tallahassee Community College (TCC) Eagle Connections Program
Apps/ Tools	• GroupMe as a communication tool with students for social events • RedCap for surveys • Google Calendar for scheduling • Brightspace for LMS • Anchor link for student organization management	• Microsoft Teams • Zoom • Qualtrics as survey tool for Mentors' daily reporting	• Text messages • Emails • Outlook Calendar • Google Forms for surveys • SharePoint for meeting minutes & resources • Excel for Mentors to complete student activities entries
Structure	Ambassa'Dores is a registered student organization, which facilitates recruitment and student organization partnerships. The leadership structure includes a president, vice president, secretary, treasurer, social chair, and recruitment chair.	The full-time peer mentor coordinates the program. Mentors' interests and engagement are used to match mentors/mentees. Weekly schedules are developed based on mentor availability and shared interests. Two team lead mentors are the first point of contact for mentors/mentees and are in daily contact with the mentor coordinator. The team lead mentors receive a 10-hour weekly stipend.	The program coordinator supervises the mentors. Experienced mentors lead training sessions and provide opportunities for job shadowing for new mentors. Mentor meetings are held twice monthly. The number of mentors is based on the needs of the students and the availability of the mentors. Mentor diversity is sought in gender, race, and disability.
Documentation & Evaluation	Every Ambassa'Dore completes a weekly check-in and reflection form for the student(s) they work alongside. Staff review and respond to the reflections. Students complete Redcap feedback surveys. Leads check in with each Ambassa'Dore in a student's circle.	Mentors submit daily Qualtrics reports to the mentor coordinator. Mentees submit weekly reflections on their experience in the program. Mentors provide information on students' Satisfactory Academic Progress and provide input on social activities and work-based learning. Mentors in the service-learning class submit journals five times each semester, describing experiences and person-centered practices and tools. Each student conducts course evaluations for each of their courses as well as by service-learning student mentors.	Mentors enter notes about each study session with a student. Program students, faculty, and the supervisor complete a Google survey about the mentor's performance. Staff collect feedback and share it with the mentor mid-semester when they also complete a self-reflection. Mentors meet frequently with each other to also share updates, reminders, and professional development topics.
Challenges	The large number of peer mentors requires a greater degree of organization, communication, and connection with the mentors.	Unpaid volunteer mentor models can be hard to manage when students get busy, have competing interests, are ill, or stressed. But creating balanced, authentic relationships are extremely important and extend beyond the time commitment that mentors make. Many extend beyond graduation.	Sustainability is a challenge as minimum wage increases and program student numbers grow. HR processes and timing can delay the start date of mentors.

PROMISING PRACTICES

In addition to the core components of a mentoring program, a few promising practices are worth mentioning:

RECIPROCITY. Identifying a relationship of reciprocity in mentor training supports individual responsibility and provides parameters while circumventing a power dynamic from entering the mentor-mentee relationship. Reciprocity is evidenced through clearly stated word choice (e.g., friendship, neurodiverse) and philosophy (VU), and identified in types of support (e.g., not... supervisors; TCC). It is interesting to note that reciprocity is most clearly evidenced in the volunteer mentor program.

EMOTIONAL SUPPORT. Wilt and Morningstar (2020) identified emotional support as intertwined with both academic and social activity support. Such emotional support is evidenced in each program when mentors focus on helping the students feel a sense of belonging (VU), making students feel welcome through introductions to peers and situations and supporting the students' self-determination (UG), and when helping students navigate new college student responsibilities and encouraging confidence and independence (TCC).

FOCUS ON SOCIAL COMPLEXITIES.

Mentors should be aware of and able to facilitate strategies and tools for such complexities of college life as developing and maintaining friendships, reasonable risk taking, and managing the responsibilities and stress (Wilt and Morningstar, 2020). Self-advocating, managing time commitments, and developing independence strategies might be good additions to this list (Giust and Valle-Riestra, 2017).

INDIVIDUAL SUPPORT. As identified in HEOA (2008), individualized support is critical to students' success. Each of the programs reflected this through customized hours of support, (VU), mentor pairing based on interests and skills (VU), planned fading of supports (TCC, UGA), and development of natural supports (UGA, TCC).

This resource was developed as the result of a 2022 Inclusive Campus Life Affinity Group meeting focused on Mentor models. You can find the ICL meeting recording on Think College website at [Inclusive Community Life Affinity Group 2022](#).



ADDITIONAL RESOURCES

[Peer Mentor Handbook examples from Think College Resources](#)

[Peer Mentor Training videos: 4 10-minute video resources for peer mentor training.](#)

[Establishing a Peer Mentor Program](#)

[Peer Mentoring: It Can Change your Life](#)

[Mentors Supporting Inclusive Higher Education](#)

[Peer Mentoring in Postsecondary Education](#)

[Peer Mentor Think College Resource Page](#)

ABOUT THE AUTHORS

LINDSAY KRECH-BOWLES, MA works with students and university partners to ensure opportunities for reciprocal learning and meaningful inclusion as the director of Campus Life and Student Supports for the Next Steps program at Vanderbilt University.

KATHLEEN BECHT, PhD works for the Think College National Coordinating Center as the Technical Assistance Coordinator, providing support and resources to families, secondary educators, and college and university faculty and staff regarding inclusive postsecondary education for individuals with intellectual disability.

HOW TO THINK COLLEGE ISSUE NO. 12, 2022

HOW TO THINK COLLEGE is a publication of Think College National Coordinating Center, a project of the Institute for Community Inclusion at the University of Massachusetts Boston, funded by the Office of Postsecondary Education (Grant No. P407B200001). The opinions contained in this document are those of the grantee and do not necessarily reflect those of the funders.

Recommended citation for this publication:
Krech-Bowles, L. & Becht, K. (2022). Mentor Models and Practices for Inclusive Postsecondary Education. How To Think College, Issue No. 12. Institute for Community Inclusion, University of Massachusetts Boston.



www.thinkcollege.net

REFERENCES

- Athamanah, L. S., Fisher, M. H., Sung, C., & Han, J. E. (2020). The experiences and perceptions of college peer mentors Interacting with students with intellectual and developmental disabilities. *Research and Practice for Persons with Severe Disabilities*, 45(4), 271-287. <https://doi.org/10.1177/1540796920953826>
- Carter, E. W., Gustafson, J. R., Mackay, M. M., Martin, K., Parley, M., Graves, J., Day, T., McCabe, L., Lazarz, H., McMillan, E., Beeson, T., Schiro-Geist, C., Williams, M., & Cayton, J. (2019). Motivations and expectations of peer mentors within inclusive higher education programs for students with intellectual disability. *Career Development and Transition for Exceptional Individuals*, 42(3), 168-178. <https://doi.org/10.1177/2165143418779989>
- Carter, E. W., & McCabe, L. (2021). Perspectives of peers within the inclusive postsecondary education movement: A systematic review. *Behavior Modification*, 45(2), 215-250. <https://doi.org/10.1177/0145445520979789>
- Culnane, M., Eisenman, L. T., & Murphy, A. (2016). College peer mentoring and students with intellectual disability: Mentors' perspectives on relationship dynamics. *Inclusion*, 4(4), 257-269. <http://doi.org/10.1352/2326-6988-4.4.257>
- Farley, J. A., Gibbons, M. M., & Cihak, D. F. (2014). Peer mentors in a postsecondary education program for students with intellectual disabilities. *College Student Journal*, 48(4), 651-660. <http://doi.org/10.13140/RG.2.2.28251.90405>
- Foster Heckman, E., Brown, S. E., & Roberts, K. D. (Fall 2007). Mentoring Partnership Project: Exploring mentoring practices for students with disabilities in postsecondary education. HEATH Resource Center Newsletter. George Washington University, Washington, D.C. Retrieved from <http://www.ist.hawaii.edu/products/>
- Gibbons, M., Taylor, A. L., Szepe, A., & Wheat, L. S. (2018). Transformative learning for peer mentors connected to a postsecondary education program for students with intellectual and developmental disabilities. *International Journal of Research on Service-Learning and Community Engagement*. 6(1) Article 10.
- Giust, A. M., & Valle-Riestra, D. M. (2017). Supporting mentors working with students with intellectual disabilities in higher education. *Journal of Intellectual Disabilities*, 21(2), 144-157. <https://doi.org/10.1177/1744629516651019>
- Griffin, M. M., Mello, M. P., Glover, C. A., Carter, E. W., & Hodapp, R. (2016). Supporting students with intellectual disability in postsecondary education: The motivations and experiences of peer mentors. *Inclusion*, 4(2), 75-88. <https://doi.org/10.1352/2326-6988-4.2.75>
- McCabe, L., Hall, C., Carter, E. W., Lee, E. B., & Bethune-Dix, L. K. (2022). Faculty perspectives on the appeal and impact of including college students with intellectual disability. *Inclusion*, 10(1), 71-86. <https://doi.org/10.1352/2326-6988-10.1.71>
- Wilt, C. L., & Morningstar, M. E. (2020). Student Perspectives on Peer Mentoring in an Inclusive Postsecondary Education Context. *Journal of Inclusive Postsecondary Education*, 2(1). <https://doi.org/10.13021/jipe.2020.2461>